Pollution of the air

Air pollution is the result of harmful substances being released into the atmosphere, such as gases or small particles called aerosols. Natural events such as volcanoes and wildfires can also lead to air pollution, but it is primarily caused by human activity. The main air pollutants are emissions from fossil-fuel-burning power stations, factories, motor vehicles, the burning of wood and dung for heat and cooking fuel, and methane from cattle, landfill sites, and fertilized fields. Poor air quality damages human health and crops, and some fossil-fuel emissions cause acid rain, which has killed forests and fish in thousands of lakes.

The World Health Organization (WHO) estimates that nine out of ten people worldwide are breathing polluted air, causing widespread illness and allergies. It is a complex situation, however, because some aerosols, depending on the composition and color of the particles, block the amount of solar radiation reaching Earth’s surface, thus having a cooling effect on the planet.